

National Assembly Building of Dhaka

A striking Modernist parliament building and a remarkable statement of power and authority in a newborn nation

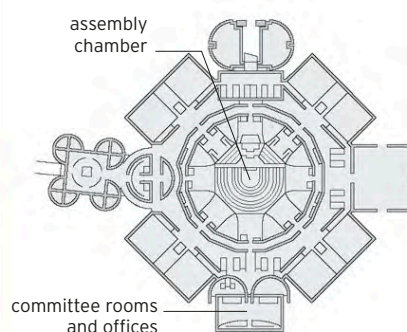


In 1962, with the decision to make East Pakistan's Dhaka the country's second capital, alongside Islamabad in West Pakistan, came the need for a space to house the National Assembly Building, or Jatiya Sangsad Bhaban. The government turned to Muzharul Islam (1923–2012), a leading Bengali architect, planner, and champion of Modernism. Islam opted to work with his former tutor at Yale University, Louis Kahn.

Kahn drew on the monumental architecture of the region, abstracting it through the prism of Modernism to create a building of bold geometric regularity. At the center of the complex is the assembly chamber, a domed amphitheater, and the library. The complex also includes a lake, gardens, and residences for members of parliament. The vast exterior walls of the main building (*Bhaban*) are deeply recessed, with porticos made from rough concrete inlaid with bands of white marble. Construction began in 1961 but was halted during East Pakistan's War of Independence in 1971 and not completed until 1982, by which time Dhaka was the capital of newly independent Bangladesh.

THE BHABAN

The *Bhaban* is actually a square that has been manipulated to form an octagon. It consists of nine individual blocks: the peripheral eight are used for committee meetings and house offices rising to 110 ft (34 m), and the central octagonal block, rising to 155 ft (47 m), is used for the national assembly.



△ POWER, PRESENCE, AND LIGHT

The architect Louis Kahn flooded the main parliament building with light that filters between the solid columns and sheer walls.

▷ AN ISLAND PARLIAMENT

The *Bhaban* sits in an artificial lake that captures the riverine beauty of Bangladesh, a country situated in the Bengal delta, the largest delta system on Earth.



△ WHITE VISTA

Most buildings in the temple are coated with white-painted plaster to symbolize the purity of the Buddha. Mirror fragments on the exterior represent the spreading of Buddhist wisdom.

▽ DESIRING HANDS

In front of the bridge of "the cycle of rebirth" are hundreds of outstretched hands representing souls suffering in hell. From here, the only way forward is into the main *ubosot*.

